

Camas Commons Proposal for Acquisition of 40 acre parcel of Talking Horse Ranch

Executive Summary

Camas Commons proposes to acquire 40 acre “Parcel A” of Talking Horse Ranch and place the property into a durable nonprofit ownership structure that preserves its agricultural, ecological, and community values for generations in partnership with The Farmers Land Trust and On Sacred Ground. The proposal brings together conservation, regenerative agriculture, affordable access to farmland and housing, ecological restoration, education, and community stewardship in a single long-term vision.

The proposed purchase price is \$1,000,000, based on the assumed value of the conservation easement, trail easement and building envelope to be created, the condition of and anticipated investment in the property's buildings and infrastructure, and the alignment of the proposed ownership structure with San Juan County Conservation Land Bank objectives. Funding will combine fundraised donations and mission-aligned loan capital, including financing through DIRT Capital Partners, and personal capital. A \$20,000 refundable earnest money deposit will be provided when the Partial Assignment and Assumption Agreement is signed (**see Attachment A**). All transaction steps and closing will be within the time frame of the existing Land Bank purchase contract.

A defining feature of the proposal is its collaborative, durable and mission aligned nonprofit ownership model. The Farmers Land Trust, a national 501(c)(3) land trust, will acquire and carry title through the acquisition process, after which ownership will be transferred to the San Juan Islands Farmland Commons, a locally forming 501(c)(25) nonprofit land-holding entity supported by the alliance of Camas Commons, The Farmers Land Trust, On Sacred Ground, and other mission aligned local nonprofits (**see Attachment J - The Farmers Land Trust Letter**). This structure is intended to ensure that the property's agricultural and conservation values remain protected while providing secure, long-term tenure for farmers through a direct and primary 99-year leasehold to Camas Commons.

Camas Commons will transition Talking Horse Ranch into a regenerative agricultural living laboratory, integrating productive farming with ecological restoration, research, education, and community engagement. Initial activities will include conservation and rotational grazing, pasture restoration, market gardening, fruit and nut production, food forests, pastured poultry, and development of a certified goat dairy. Camas Commons aims to build on these operations and add more in through both non-residential and residential agricultural operations to provide greater productivity to the farm as a whole, and more local provisions for the local food system.

The farming operations are intended to improve soil health, increase water retention, support biodiversity, reduce wildfire risk, strengthen local food production, and build climate resilience.

The project also addresses a critical challenge for the next generation of farmers: affordable and secure access to both land and housing. The property contains four development rights, two of which are already utilized by the two existing homes. The long-term vision is to connect remaining development opportunities with 99-year agricultural ground leases, allowing additional farmers to build and own homes while establishing viable agricultural enterprises. Multiple farm enterprises can share infrastructure, knowledge, and resources while keeping the property dedicated to agriculture. (**See Attachment G - Site Map**)

Camas Commons will also function as a community resource, providing opportunities for youth and adults through outdoor education, workshops, internships, mentorships, volunteer days, farmer-to-farmer exchanges, seasonal events, and ecological stewardship programs. Partnerships with local schools, community organizations, and Indigenous organizations will expand opportunities for agricultural learning, food sovereignty, and community connection.

The Camas Common's proposal is led by Ally Rugge and Guiseppi Spadafora, current residents and land stewards of Talking Horse Ranch in collaboration with local, On Sacred Ground Land Trust, and the national non-profit, The Farmers Land Trust as a partner and advisor for establishing a land trust. Together, Guiseppi and Ally bring nearly four decades of complementary experience in organic agriculture, livestock care, land stewardship, sustainable infrastructure, construction, homesteading, project management, and community organizing, along with direct knowledge of the property and its agricultural potential. There are several known hazards and maintenance requirements across parcels that have been identified under current tenancy that need to be addressed, and this institutional knowledge is a key asset that no other applicant has, nor will have access to as a new owner.

Through the land trust model, Camas Commons offers the Land Bank a collaborative conservation opportunity to also include the 40 acres in conjunction with the 80 acres, ensuring all 120 acres are preserved beyond a single generation. The model also offers a durable pathway to keep the land working, restore its ecological health, create secure opportunities for farmers to live and farm, and ensure that the benefits of the property remain connected to the San Juan Island community for generations.

Terms

Price is \$1,000,000 based on viable funding secured and in recognition of:

- Value of the to-be-conveyed agricultural conservation easement and included to be created building envelopes and trail easement (*see Additional Material and Attachment H - Valuation Considerations*)
- Condition of and consideration of repair and maintenance of buildings and infrastructure
- Values alignment with Land Bank objectives and preservation of such values through unique, durable, mission aligned and sustainable nonprofit land ownership structure proposed.
- Institutional Knowledge Asset: Ally and Guisepe's firsthand knowledge of the entire 120-acre property, infrastructure, and systems is a value-added asset that reduces transition and maintenance costs, time and workload for the Land Bank's ownership of the 80-acres.
- Realistic and viable funding structure for acquisition, project costs, long-term endowment and stewardship, and operational needs going forward.

Financing is comprised of fundraised donations and mission aligned and supportive loan capital:

\$206,000 in fundraised donations, as of September 30th - secured through direct donations and pledges held by nonprofit fiscal sponsor - fundraising will continue and will also accelerate upon successful securing of the Option to Purchase through RFP process

\$300,000 of personal capital comprised of \$100,000 from Guisepe Spadafora and Ally Rugge and \$200,000 from their families.

Up to \$600,000 in debt financing through DIRT Capital Partners - an impact-first investment firm founded in 2014 to acquire and fund acquisition of farmland in partnership with partner organizations and regenerative farmers to provide secure land access and a clear path to ownership for farmers and community structures

Refundable Earnest Money Escrow Deposit of \$20,000 provided when Partial Assignment and Assumption Agreement is signed. (*see Attachment A*).

Due Diligence will be completed within 30 days of accepted RFP proposal and signing of Partial Assignment and Assumption Agreement, and completed on November 15th, or before.

Purchase would be completed within the timeframe of the existing Purchase Contract held by the Land Bank.

Terms also include the negotiating and completion of an agricultural conservation easement and trail easement prior to closing (*See *Additional Materials provided by legal counsel* to Lincoln*).

Introduction

Talking Horse Ranch is currently the only farm that offers the conditions, landscape, infrastructure, housing and development rights that integrate critical community needs being met through a timely solution.

The islands have a history of setting precedents. Establishing the Land Bank was one of them. Becoming the only county in Washington state to prohibit the propagation of GMOs was another. Creating the Lopez Island Community Land Trust over thirty years ago when the cost of housing rose 190% in a single year, which has now served as a nationwide model, was yet another. These innovative examples considered together bring forward the values of how land is held and preserved, how regenerative farming is valued to steward the land, and how affordable housing for agrarian land based residents is important. Camas Commons is our proposal for the future of these 40 acres of Talking Horse Ranch to become a shining example of all three of these values. **Bringing ownership of these 40 acres into a land trust, the San Juan Islands Farmland Commons, through the alliance of Camas Commons, The Farmers Land Trust, a national nonprofit, and On Sacred Ground, an established local non-profit, is an opportunity to set another precedent in a pivotal time for the islands to address land access for farmers using regenerative practices, affordable residential opportunities for those stewarding the land and the community, and preserving the land in ways that align deeply with Land Bank's mandate and values.**

Facing the loss of places they loved, a diverse group of locals sought a way to save treasured lands and maintain quality of life. Their vision led to the creation of the San Juan County Conservation Land Bank. (as stated on Land Bank's Community Foundation page).

We, too, are now facing the loss of a place we love, and with a diverse group of locals and national support, are creating a way to save this treasured land and maintain quality of life for our local community. The island has been facing the loss of critical farmland following suit to a nationwide problem. Our vision has led to the creation of Camas Commons - a regenerative farming organization to ensure the 40 acres of Talking Horse Ranch's 120 acres not only maintains agriculture, but is granted the opportunity to take agriculture on the islands to a new level that meets the needs of our time. Regenerative agriculture is the future of farming and our islands are perfectly poised to adopt this practice as the standard in our region. Camas Commons provides multifaceted solutions now for long overdue community needs. These include, but are not limited to: affordable farmland access and housing opportunities for young farmers, reviving agricultural skills & knowledge, food security, wildfire mitigation, drought tolerance and water conservation. Regenerative agriculture focuses on soil health as the foundation to healthy, thriving ecosystems that produce greater yields in pasture, pollination, livestock fodder, fruits & veggies, and even in recharging watersheds. Improving our island soils to produce more and

better food for ourselves and support the health of our ecosystem grounded in a stewardship model that blends the strengths of conservation and agriculture is at the core of Camas Commons founding principles.

As current land stewards of Talking Horse Ranch, we have gathered a diverse group of locals from corresponding fields and backgrounds to join together and save this treasured farm as a community asset. We have come together to form Camas Commons to create a path to establish quality of life for young farmers seeking access to farmland, housing, and viable agricultural income and in doing so grows the quality of life for our island community as a whole for the long term, while also contributing to the local food system.

Camas Commons Mission Statement

To preserve and protect farmland and natural resources through stewardship of productive agricultural lands, open spaces, rural heritage, and natural ecosystems. We strive to strengthen our community by keeping land and housing opportunities accessible and affordable for farmers and producers, while fostering meaningful community partnerships and endeavors. Through education, research, and hands-on engagement, we support regenerative farming, ecological stewardship, traditional skills, and deeper connections to nature. We provide a living space for scientific research and innovation that advances understanding of soil health and creating resilient ecosystems.

The Farmers Land Trust

A Delaware nonstock 501(c)(3) nonprofit land trust working nationally to transact farmland (real estate, fundraising, legal) into community ownership through the Farmland Commons, which are local land holding nonprofit entities that then give 99-year, secure, affordable, and equitable lease tenure to next generation farmers using chemical free, regenerative agriculture. The San Juan Islands Farmland Commons is the locally forming affiliate 501(c)(25). **(See Attachment B Intro to the Farmland Commons)**

Goals for Farm

1. To transition Talking Horse Ranch into a regenerative farm that establishes a model for farming that nurtures soil health and climate change resilience that results in a variety of benefits that meet important needs of our time. (*Regenerative Farming principles, link: <https://regenerativefarmingpractices.com/5-principles-of-regenerative-agriculture/>*)

Operations that will reflect these principles in the initial year include, but are not limited to:

- a. Conservation/adaptive/rotational grazing
- b. Market garden

- c. Preparations for certification of goat dairy
 - d. Pastured chickens
 - e. Pasture Restoration Project (completed Ag. Guild Grant & February Report)
 - f. Fruit Tree & Berry Production (already have begun)
 - g. Fruit & Nut Tree Nursery for future Orchard Site
 - h. Design of Food Forest plan
2. To provide affordable access to land and housing opportunities for young farmers to live on the land they farm through affordable home site equity buy-in and long-term affordable ground lease tenure.
 3. To establish a thriving farm with a variety of agricultural operations that helps provide an abundance of diverse local, healthy foods for the islands.
 4. Economic development for the islands through reducing costs for the on-site farmers and helping establish diversification of income streams that the unique landscape, micro-climates and infrastructure of Talking Horse Ranch offers. These key ingredients are not present on any other local historic farmland that is currently available to offer the integrated solutions that Camas Commons provides for the community's long overdue needs of affordable land access, housing and growing the island's food security.
 5. Climate Change resilience through Regenerative farming practices:
 - a. restore and build soil health to sequester carbon and grow healthy food
 - b. recharge water sources, increase water storage in soils and movement of water on land for natural irrigation
 - c. cultivate and steward diverse and healthy farm ecosystem
 - d. grow food for the local community to both create abundance and lower food miles and be part of increasing the percent of locally grown food
 6. Educational opportunities and programs for kids K-12, as well as adults to ensure important farming knowledge and skills are getting passed on to future generations, and stewardship places humans in an essential role in contributing to the vitality of our local environment.
 7. Maintain the land of Talking Horse Ranch as a community asset to contribute to local resilience in all the ways a true working farm can provide as a resource center of knowledge, enterprise, food production, education and social engagement that meet not only our basic human needs of the physical, but our needs that are unseen – deeply felt– social, emotional, mental needs that encompass how quality of life impacts health.

Goals for Land

Establish a living laboratory for regenerative farming that positions the farm as a long-term site for scientific research, applied learning, and community stewardship. The laboratory will provide a real-world setting to study how regenerative agricultural and conservation practices can work together as a holistic approach to land management, to build a body of credible, place-based knowledge that demonstrates what works, why it works, and how those practices can be adapted and replicated. In doing so, the farm becomes more than a place where agriculture occurs; it becomes a living repository of knowledge and stewardship, demonstrating the interconnectedness of productive agriculture, healthy ecosystems, and community well-being while creating a lasting legacy for the farm and the island it serves.

Goals for Restoration are:

1. To repair and enrich soils in the pasture, paddocks, and garden.
 - To Increase organic matter
 - To Increase water absorption, and reduce water consumption
 - To Increase soil microbes
2. To mitigate wildfire risk.
3. To find a balance between restoring and preserving natural ecology, and cultivating non-native species used in agriculture.
4. To act as a regional hub for education regarding regenerative agriculture, sustainability, and traditional skills.
5. To work with a team from corresponding fields of conservation and agriculture to aid in the quest of restoring pastures into healthy, living ecosystems that provide greater food security for the soil, essential livestock, plants & pollinators, and the island community as a whole, which offer a larger return on investment for the farming operations in the long term.

Previous Farming Experience

Ally Rugge and Guisepi Spadafora bring a combined background of nearly four decades of organic agriculture, land stewardship, sustainable infrastructure, homesteading, animal husbandry, project management, construction, volunteer coordination, and community organizing. Their experience is rooted in hands-on work with land and farms, with an emphasis on ecological practices, local food systems, resource conservation, and community resilience.

Ally Rugge – Relevant Experience

Ally's experience spans organic farming, land stewardship, animal raising, project management, fundraising, volunteer coordination, and community-based agricultural work.

Ally has extensive experience in coordination & management, which she often either steps into naturally to fill the need, or is hired, often on the spot to do so. She began her professional career as a project manager with Communicatus Design firm in Virginia, developing skills in organization, coordination, scheduling, and project implementation. She went on to be hired as the manager of Miro Tea in Seattle, Washington when it first opened. She subsequently pursued extensive hands-on agricultural experience, including work at Talking Horse Ranch in its flagship season in 2010, and continued seasonal farm and market garden support through 2013. Ally also volunteered at a Demeter Biodynamic Farm in Germany and has worked or volunteered on numerous farms, homesteads and agricultural organizations throughout the United States until returning to San Juan Island in 2018.

Her agricultural experience includes organic food production, farm labor, gardening, animal care, homesteading, and working within diverse small-scale farming systems. She has also developed experience in community food and ecological organizations, including serving as a volunteer fundraiser for Brickworks, coordinating volunteers and organizational activities at The Ecology Center in San Juan Capistrano, California. She served as a Lead Volunteer with Common Vision's Fruit Tree Tour, working with under-served schools providing hands-on education of fruit tree care and planting alongside students at chosen orchard sites on schoolgrounds.

As the start-up manager, Ally led legal administrative work and operations management in the renovation and opening of a natural food store in West Virginia, giving her experience beyond production itself and into the broader infrastructure and community context of local food systems.

From 2019–2022, Ally maintained a homestead and garden on San Juan Island, including personal gardening and beginner chicken keeping. This period strengthened her familiarity with island conditions, seasonal growing, self-sufficiency, and small-scale livestock care.

Since 2022, Ally has served as Land Steward at Talking Horse Ranch, where she is currently practicing holistic animal management and traditional herding techniques, implementing rotational grazing practices, and developing a dairy goat herd with the long-term goal of establishing a certified goat dairy on the farm. Her dairy operation includes an intentional breeding program focused on developing a specialty San Juan Island heavy-milking Mini Nubian goat line, adapted to the local environment and suited to productive, sustainable small-scale dairy production. She is currently in the initial year of this breeding program, laying the foundation for a locally adapted herd through careful selection, and hands-on management.

In 2024, Ally founded the Women Who Stare at Goats Collective, a community centered around goats, holistic animal care, and shared agricultural knowledge. The Collective intends to grow into a multigenerational mentoring and educational program organized around concentric circles of care, learning, and leadership. The program envisions a “little sister–big sister–grandmother” model in which participants of different ages learn from and support one another through shared agricultural activities, animal care, and common goals. Rather than separating generations, the model creates opportunities for knowledge and responsibility to move in multiple directions—connecting youth, adults, and elders through meaningful work and relationships. Through hands-on activities with animals, gardens, land, and one another, the program aims to cultivate leadership, confidence, practical skills, social connection, and intergenerational belonging. Ally's vision is to create a setting where agricultural knowledge is not only taught but practiced collectively, while relationships across generations become an integral part of the learning process.

Through her work raising animals and assisting with Rob Waldron’s livestock operation over the years, Ally has developed extensive, hands-on experience in animal care and crisis management. Her training has included learning and administering life-saving treatments in situations where veterinary care was not immediately available. She has also personally financed and completed coursework in holistic goat care, including the use of natural and herbal treatments, preventative care, and supportive practices. These approaches have contributed to the overall health of her herd and have been associated with higher milk production and milk quality.

Through both formal coursework and extensive experiential learning, Ally has become a trusted resource among fellow farmers and animal keepers. She is often sought out to help assess sick or injured animals and provide guidance on treatment when veterinary services are unavailable. From her experience, she has also advised others on preventative-maintenance practices that have contributed to improvements to other herds on the island. She has consistently provided this assistance at no cost, reflecting the longstanding agricultural tradition of farmers-helping-farmers and sharing practical knowledge within their community.

Together, these experiences provide Ally with a broad practical foundation in crop production, livestock, animal health and birthing, pasture-based systems, gardening, land stewardship, farm organization, and community engagement. This work builds upon Ally's extensive experience in organic agriculture, homesteading, animal care, and land stewardship, and reflects her long-term commitment to developing an integrated agricultural operation rooted in responsible livestock management, rotational grazing, local food production, and ecological stewardship.

Guisepi Spadafora – Relevant Experience

Guisepi brings 20 years of experience designing, building, maintaining, and improving sustainable infrastructure, along with extensive hands-on experience on farms and homesteads. He tends to see things as whole systems rather than isolated objects and follows a Systems Thinking approach in his design work. He focuses on how objects interact to create connections and evaluating how the outputs of one object can become the input for another. His work centers on mapping these interactions and making deliberate plans to situate objects—whether plants, buildings, water systems, components, animals, or others—in relative location to one another to help facilitate the efficiency and efficacy of systems. This skill is essential to the foundation of permaculture and regenerative practices that are rooted in holistic agriculture.

His technical background includes solar energy systems, greywater, rainwater catchment, reclaimed materials, natural building, farm infrastructure, maintenance, alternative fuels/energy, and resource-efficient systems design. He has worked on infrastructure and maintenance projects at farms throughout the country, giving him experience adapting systems and solving practical problems in working agricultural environments.

Guisepi served as Lead Builder for the earth-friendly renovation of a natural food store in West Virginia and worked in facilities and small-scale building at The Ecology Center in San Juan Capistrano, California, doing both agricultural and educational projects. He also participated in Common Vision's Fruit Tree Tour for two years, and has approximately four years of organic farming experience in California.

For ten years, Guisepi operated the Free Tea Bus, a nationwide community-oriented project requiring substantial logistical planning, mobile infrastructure, maintenance, transportation, and community engagement. His bus was powered by waste vegetable oil and solar systems that he built. This experience strengthened his ability to manage complex projects independently and work collaboratively with diverse communities.

From 2019–2022, Guisepi maintained a personal homestead and garden on San Juan Island, developing direct experience with island-specific growing, homesteading, and resource-management conditions.

Since 2022, Guisepi has served as Land Steward, handyman, builder and been in charge of facilities management at Talking Horse Ranch. He has also served as a board member of Alchemy Art Center since 2019 (Secretary 2023-present), contributing to organizational development, community programming, and collaborative decision-making, including participating in the growth of the organization from one campus to two – with the acquisition and transformation of the Lavender Farm.

Complementary Capacity

Ally and Guisepe's experience is complementary: Ally's primary strengths are in agriculture, animal husbandry, gardening, land stewardship, project coordination, and community organizing, while Guisepe brings extensive expertise in infrastructure, construction, sustainable systems, maintenance, and practical problem-solving.

Together, they have experience with both the living systems and the physical infrastructure required to operate a working farm. Their background includes growing food, caring for livestock, managing pasture and gardens, maintaining land, designing and repairing infrastructure, conserving water and other resources, coordinating volunteers, and building community around agricultural and ecological projects.

Their experience on San Juan Island, including their homesteading and gardening work from 2019–2022 and their land stewardship at Talking Horse Ranch since 2022, has also given them direct familiarity with the local landscape and the practical realities of farming and land management in the San Juan Islands.

This combination of agricultural, ecological, technical, organizational, and community experience provides a strong foundation for maintaining the property's agricultural heritage while developing a resilient, productive, and locally connected farm operation.

Qualifications: Current residents of Talking Horse Ranch and have been preparing the way for the next chapter of the farm.

Guisepe and Ally have direct knowledge of the property and its agricultural potential. They also have a long-standing relationship with Rob Waldron, who has farmed the land for the last twenty years, whose intimate, historical knowledge of the land, infrastructure and systems surpasses any living person at present. Combined, these are vital aspects to taking on a historic agricultural property that no other applicant has, nor will have access to as a new owner. To the Land Bank's benefit, Ally and Guisepe can be available to support needs and information to support Land Bank's staff for the remaining eighty acres. Through this role, it will reduce costs, workload and time for the Land Bank that will provide a judicious use of tax-payer resources and staff productivity as a result. This institutional knowledge is an intangible asset which no other applicant can offer.

Ally and Guisepe are both natural problem solvers and enjoy applying solutions that are rooted in alternative pathways, creative thinking and applied knowledge based on experience. Their observations from past work on a variety of farms, homesteads and agricultural organizations laid the groundwork for their vision for Camas Commons. Their findings involve the following:

- 1) Homesteads and farms often consisted of 1-2 people doing every part of the farmwork, some even working full-time jobs as well. Land-based work and living needs capable, enthusiastic, hard-working, committed people, year-round.
- 2) Often help was seasonal and lacked the necessary housing/facilities to offer year-round/full-time help. There was often a revolving door of transient, young workers who couldn't commit beyond the summer season due to this, even though they wanted to and the farmers wanted them to. Long-term housing opportunities are an essential ingredient to facilitating commitment to the year-round work that agricultural operations require.
- 3) Farmers were spread thin over many areas that required daily attention and care. Production suffered, livestock's well-being suffered and resources were wasted due to farmers trying to provide everything or "do it all" which resulted in haphazard operations that depleted resources. In order to farm well, focusing on a few niche operations and diversifying income from these areas of focus allowed the operation to not only be run better, but generated viable income and interest due to the quality of product(s) produced from this approach that resulted in customer loyalty.
- 4) People in the community desire to support local farms, spend time on them and learn where their food comes from and desire to participate on farms in a more personal way beyond being a customer. Farm hospitality, seasonal events, agriculture & land based education were an untapped reservoir of community support and income generation for farmers.
- 5) Many farmers were spending a lot of money on outside inputs to build greater productivity. Farming that focused on permaculture, regenerative practices and biodynamic farming didn't need as many (or any) outside inputs but utilized the outputs of one operation as an input for another, reducing costs and building soil that produced greater crop yields. Food forests also helped develop habitat for pollinators which contributed to greater honey yields and ensured greater success of winter survival for producing honeybees.
- 6) Farms are untapped resource centers of abundance beyond food for the community that not only have the ability to be a hub for social engagement, food-based education, life skills and land connection, but provide a number of by-products from the operations for at-home gardening and land-based needs that result in easy, viable income.
- 7) Due to lack of affordable land access and housing opportunities, many farming operations that require higher demands of care are treated like an office job rather than a producing home to be nurtured. This often results in unfortunate accidents or preventable deaths in many livestock operations, as well as crop issues from malfunctioning irrigation systems and waste of resources with water being left running. Also the commute adds more time, energy and fuel being used by the farmer. When available multiple farmers need to be on farmland to create a thriving farm, as well as build a network of interconnected operations to reduce costs and be able to rely on one another to be an effective use of

time, energy, and resources, which results in greater success for the farming operations and therefore the community's food security as a whole. Living on the land prevents the dual-overhead costs associated with having to have a separate residence and agricultural operation.

How proposed agricultural activities will contribute to the local agricultural food system:

The 2025 San Juan County Community Food Assessment identified numerous challenges facing our island communities and local food system, including issues related to agricultural capacity, food access, local food production, and long-term food security. ([*See the assessment: 2025 San Juan County Community Food Assessment*](#))

Camas Commons is designed to directly contribute to strengthening the local agricultural and food system in response to many of the needs identified in the assessment. Just a few of the initiatives outlined below represent specific ways our proposed plan seeks to address these challenges and support a more resilient, accessible, and locally-based food system.

As outlined in **The 2025 San Juan County Community Food Assessment**, the full proposed plan for Camas Commons is intended to address a significant majority of the needs and opportunities identified through the assessment, while creating additional community benefits that support local agriculture, food security, education, and long-term resilience.

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1. With silvo-pastures, livestock operations following conservation grazing methods, food forests, market gardens and a variety of cottage industries the farm can produce thousands of pounds of farm products for local consumption — from vegetables to meat to dairy to honey, and other products, including specialty goods that can only be found at our farm. Utilizing our local food hub, farmers market and food co-op as options for re-sale of our products. We also see our farm store and the farm itself as a destination site for locals and tourists given that the farm will be the only farm located along a non-motorized trail from town as a result of the plans for extending the Beaverton Marsh trail.
2. Through educational programs, workshops, mentorships, learning exchanges and 4-h opportunities, we'll grow agricultural skills for growers outside the farm, empowering the community to engage their own homes, backyards and landscapes as places of production through regenerative practices. This will support community members in being able to contribute to soil & water restoration around the island, ensuring that other parts of the island benefit from the practices developed on the farm. Based on the success that high schools around the nation have had in offering farming related programs and curriculum,

we plan to partner with island schools and the Family Resource Center to offer outdoor, farming education and mentorships to also ensure that children of all ages who are interested in agriculture have access to these skills.

(for data see links:

- a. <https://www.ffa.org/97th-national-ffa-convention-expo/membership-mile-stone-ffa-one-million/>,
- b. <https://www.cfra.org/blog/farm-school-movement-has-exploded-across-country>)

3. The 40 acres of Talking Horse Ranch includes four development rights. Two of those rights have already been utilized for the existing homesites, which includes our home, and another house that will be available for occupancy following the purchase. The long-term vision is to use the remaining development opportunities to create 99-year agricultural leases associated with the individual homesites, providing farmers with the opportunity to build and own their own homes, while establishing and operating their own agricultural enterprises on the property. This model is intended to create more than a place for us to farm. It is an opportunity in which multiple farmers can establish independent enterprises while sharing land-based resources, infrastructure and knowledge. By creating secure, long-term tenure for additional farmers, the project can help address one of the significant challenges facing small-scale agriculture: access to land and a stable place from which to build a farm business. Farmers will have the opportunity to invest in their homes and agricultural operations with the security of a 99-year lease, while the property as a whole will remain connected to its agricultural purpose. The result would be the potential for several additional farming enterprises to operate on the property, increasing the amount and diversity of agricultural activity within the local community. These enterprises will complement one another, create opportunities for collaboration and shared infrastructure, and contribute to a more resilient local food and agricultural system. Camas Commons is therefore not simply to acquire and operate a farm, but to create a long-term framework for additional farmers to establish themselves, build meaningful livelihoods, and contribute to the agricultural community of San Juan County.

The goal is not only to provide accessibility, but to empower future generations with the knowledge, know-how and business savvy to develop viable agricultural operations in the future. The youth programs may also offer a clear pathway to ensuring there are young, capable farmers to pass Camas Commons farming operations and housing onto when older farmers are ready to retire. With these objectives at the core of our educational programming for all-ages, we will support the island's culture of productive farming. A model that through balancing the combined strengths of conservation and agriculture, meets the needs of our modern times, including the effects of climate change.

Funding Plan

Camas Commons has developed a diversified funding strategy to support the **\$1,000,000 acquisition of Talking Horse Ranch** and the associated project costs, as noted in the attached Acquisition Budget (**See Attachment C**), combining significant personal and family investment, committed philanthropic support from individual donors and community organizations, continued fundraising, and acquisition financing.

The strategy demonstrates substantial financial commitment while providing the flexibility needed to manage the timing of fundraising and acquisition requirements.

Sources of Funding

<u>TOTAL REVENUE</u>	FUNDING	STATUS
Donations as of 9.30.26	\$ 206,000.00	raised
G & A home purchase funds	\$ 100,000.00	funded
G & A family home purchase funds	\$ 200,000.00	funded
FUNDRAISE TOTAL	\$ 506,000.00	
LOW END NEED - Donations 10.1.26 to 1.10.27	\$ 240,000.00	needed
DIRT Capital Mortgage Capital Need	\$ 597,000.00	pre-approval
TOTAL REVENUE	\$ 1,343,000.00	
<u>TOTAL COST</u>		
Farm Purchase	\$1,000,000	
Transaction Costs and Endowment Reserves	\$343,000	
TOTAL	\$ 1,343,000.00	

Guisepi and Ally have committed \$300,000 of their own and family funds toward fundraising and to acquire and own their home and limited accessory structures at Talking Horse Ranch. This substantial personal investment reflects their long-term commitment to the property while the broader fundraising effort focuses on the acquisition and stewardship of the ranch as a community resource.

Camas Commons has also secured **\$206,000 in committed donations** in less than seven weeks. This early response demonstrates meaningful community support and provides a strong foundation for the next stage of the campaign.

For up-to-date fundraising numbers, please visit camascommons.org and see the thermometer to see our fundraise total.

Continued Fundraising

Beginning **October 16, Camas Commons will have approximately 11 weeks to pursue an additional \$240,000 in donations prior to acquisition.** This goal builds directly on the momentum already established.

We believe that **selection of our proposal by the Land Bank will be a significant catalyst for this next phase of fundraising.** Selection will give current and prospective donors greater confidence that Camas Commons has a viable path toward acquiring and stewarding Talking Horse Ranch. It will also allow us to approach a broader circle of supporters with a compelling story: that the community has rallied around the property, that substantial funding is already in place, and that the project has a credible path toward acquisition.

Acquisition Financing

In partnership with The Farmers Land Trust, Camas Commons has received pre-approval from DIRT Capital for up to **\$600,000** in acquisition financing (***See Attachment D - Funding Approval Letter***).

This pre-approval provides an important financing backstop for the project. The availability of up to **\$600,000** gives Camas Commons the flexibility needed to move forward with the acquisition while fundraising continues.

A Clear Path to Acquisition

Together, these funding sources provide Camas Commons with a strong and flexible pathway toward completing the **\$1,000,000 acquisition of Talking Horse Ranch.**

Most importantly, this funding strategy reflects a shared commitment to making Talking Horse Ranch a lasting community asset. Guiseppi and Ally's personal investment, the early generosity of donors, the opportunity to build additional support following Land Bank selection, and the DIRT Capital financing backstop together create a solid financial foundation for Camas Commons to move from proposal to acquisition and long-term stewardship.

Buyer and Ownership Structure

The Farmers Land Trust (an agricultural 501(c)(3)) will carry title to the property through the purchase process. Upon establishment and completion of all necessary legal requirements, title will be transferred to the San Juan Islands Farmland Commons as a 501(c)(25) land trust, a local entity that will be connected to and supported by local, regional, and national nonprofits.

Proposed Actions after Closing

First 6-12 months.

- The Farmers Land Trust will carry title to the property through the purchase process.
- **Develop Regenerative Agriculture Lease Program:** a clear application and selection process for both non-residential and residential leases that establishes the expectations and commitments necessary to transition the property into regenerative agriculture.
- **Develop Farm Operations Documents:** Create the legal and operational documents governing Camas Commons' use and management of the property, including a long-term ground lease which includes operating responsibilities, Operations Budget (**See Attachment E**), land stewardship requirements, maintenance obligations, insurance requirements, and procedures for addressing changes or disputes.
- **Establish the Farm Advisory Board:** Establish the Camas Commons Farm Advisory Board and its membership, roles, responsibilities, decision-making authority, meeting procedures. The Advisory Board will provide ongoing guidance and support for farm operations, ecological stewardship, community engagement, and long-term decision-making. This will include some of our Acquisition Advisory Board members but is not limited to those members. Farm Advisory Board will include representatives from on-site farming operations, developed partnerships with Indigenous organizations through On Sacred Ground, and other local organizations that specialize in complimentary fields that meet the holistic farm plan of Camas Commons vision.
- **Develop Land Trust Governance Documents:** Working with The Farmers Land Trust, nonprofit partners and legal counsel – develop the San Juan Island Farmland Commons shared agreements and governance documents, including bylaws, policies, and other documents necessary to incorporate the entity and establish clear and accountable stewardship of the land.
- **Develop Volunteer Program:** Establish a structured volunteer program with incentive-based participation tiers, roles, scheduling, training, safety protocols, and recognition. Volunteers will support farm operations, seasonal events, agricultural learning experiences, youth programs, and community activities while building opportunities for hands-on education and meaningful long-term engagement.
- **Design & Prep Market Garden for Initial Productive Season:** Develop a productive 2027 market garden plan, including assignment of a Market Garden Manager, site and garden-bed design, soil preparation, irrigation planning, equipment and supplies, and selection of an initial crop plan. The project will establish first-year production systems, planting schedules, harvest and market plans, and the infrastructure needed for long-term garden success. Support will also include development and submission of a 2027 Farm Fund grant application to the Agricultural Guild to secure start-up funding.
(**See Attachment I - Market Garden**)

- **Design Food Forest Plan:** Partner with Regenerative Earthworks, SPC, to guide, map and implement our long-term vision for food forests and design for pond pasture sites (Pond Commons) in preparation for long-term farm plan in conjunction with conservation district.
- **Horse Boarding & Tenant Development:** Develop and implement horse boarding agreements, establish boarding rates, operating policies, and secure initial tenants to create a reliable earned-income stream supporting long-term operations. The boarding program will also establish a foundation for first-year youth educational programming focused on horse and livestock care, responsible animal stewardship, conservation grazing and hands-on agricultural-conservation learning.
- **Develop Maintenance & Safety Plan:** Continue to locate and inventory potential hazard sites and infrastructure improvements to establish needed maintenance, repairs and safety protocols. There are several known hazards and maintenance requirements across parcels that have been identified under current tenancy that need to be addressed.
- **Seasonal Events & Agritourism:** Develop an annual calendar and operating plan for seasonal farm events that build community engagement, provide hands-on agricultural experiences, and create new agritourism-based revenue. Initial activities may include seasonal harvest events, farm tours, workshops, youth programming, and community gatherings.
- **Research and Develop Dairy Certification Requirements:** Proceed with plan to develop a certified goat dairy site for Women Who Stare at Goats Collective.
- **Continued Fundraising:** Research and apply for grants specific to the nature of farm goals through partnered non-profits. **Example:** Agricultural Guild's annual Farm Fund for start-up of market garden. Meet with The Community Foundation about establishing an active fundraiser campaign for Camas Commons. Plan the first Spring Equinox 'Donor Day' fundraiser celebration.

Initial Stages of Long-term Goals and Regenerative Agriculture Development

The long-term farm goals will establish Camas Commons as an integrated regenerative landscape where housing, agriculture, ecological restoration, education, and community partnerships reinforce one another. Leaseholders and partners will participate in a shared stewardship framework designed to ensure that development and productive use of the property contribute to the health and resilience of the land and the community in which the farm serves.

1. Infrastructure and Site Development

- Develop a comprehensive long-term farm and site plan through Regenerative Earthworks, SPC, establishing the framework for agricultural production, residential sites, ecological restoration, infrastructure, education, and community use.

- Extend power, water, and driveway access to each designated residential home-site while minimizing impacts on agricultural soils, water systems, habitat, and existing ecological features.
- Design infrastructure improvements that align with the farm's regenerative goals, incorporating conservation, water stewardship, soil health, energy efficiency, and low-impact development practices wherever feasible.
- Assess octagon barn for necessary improvements in preparation for dairy certification requirements through Women Who Stare at Goats Collective.

2. Regenerative Agriculture Lease Program

- **Year 1 — Initial Productive Season:** Prioritize non-residential agricultural leases for farm operations that meet Camas Commons' stewardship standards while contributing to the farm's intended products, services, and overall economic viability. These ongoing agricultural leases will support the productive use of the land, strengthen farm operations, and maintain the long-term capacity of the property to function within a regenerative farming model.
- **January 2028 — Residential Trial Program:** Begin the initial stages of the residential application process for carefully structured two-year residential trial periods. This phased approach will allow the agricultural operations and land stewardship systems to become established before introducing residential components, while providing an opportunity to evaluate how residential participation can complement the farm's broader goals and ensure commitment to these goals.

3. Trial Production Season 2027-2028

- Map conservation and adaptive grazing paddocks and timeline.
- Prioritize establishing core regenerative enterprises and demonstrating the farm's capacity for production and ecological restoration.
- Establish and plant the market garden, prioritizing crops suited to the site, soil-building practices, and the farm's long-term production goals.
- Continue the pasture restoration project using regenerative grazing, monitoring productivity and tending growth of Alfalfa, and living willow fence.
- Move forward with the design and implementation of a food forest. Plant fruit and nut trees from the nursery to create guilds with a variety of herbs, natives and pollinator plants to integrate perennial food production in pond pasture (Pond Commons) that will establish the first demonstration garden for the public to enjoy.
- Evaluate additional non-residential lease opportunities based on their ability to meet land stewardship requirements while contributing to the farm's desired products and services.
- Establish plan & schedule for seasonal events to build community engagement and agricultural activities that develop agritourism-based income.

4. Outdoor Education and Learning Exchange Programs

- Connect educational programming directly to active farm enterprises—including the market garden, pasture restoration, beekeeping, and ecological projects—so participants can learn through direct engagement with the land.
- Develop outdoor education and learning exchange programs for the late spring and summer seasons, using the farm as a living classroom.
- Create opportunities for workshops, seasonal events, open farm days, hands-on learning, youth programs, internships, volunteer days, farmer-to-farmer exchanges, and other experiential education.

5. Community Partnerships and Collaborative Programs

- Develop on-site collaborations and programming with Overmarsh Commons, local Indigenous organizations (with support of On-Sacred Ground's established partnerships), creating opportunities for cultural learning, youth leadership, food sovereignty, and community-building.

6. Establish Certified Goat Dairy for Women Who Stare at Goats

- Begin barn renovations and facility improvements to support Women Who Stare at Goats Collective and future dairy operations.
- Pursue state certification and licensing requirements for a small-scale goat dairy.
- Meet with the county planning department to review zoning, permitting, and compliance requirements for on-site dairy operations.

In Conclusion

Camas Commons is an ownership model for preserving active farmland to support farmers, housing and regenerative stewardship. Camas Commons proposes the acquisition and long-term stewardship of the 40-acre agricultural portion of Talking Horse Ranch as a permanently protected, community-oriented working farm. Our proposal brings together regenerative agriculture, conservation, affordable farmer housing, local food production, ecological restoration, education, and community stewardship within a durable nonprofit ownership structure. The islands have a history of creating innovative models for land conservation and community resilience. The establishment of the San Juan County Conservation Land Bank, the creation of the Lopez Island Community Land Trust, and other locally developed approaches to protecting land and community are examples of island communities responding creatively to challenges that affect both land and people. Camas Commons builds on that tradition.

As the current land stewards of Talking Horse Ranch, we have experienced firsthand both the potential of this property and the challenges facing farmers seeking secure access to land and housing. Together with a diverse group of local participants, organizations and national nonprofit

partners, we have developed a proposal that seeks not simply to preserve the 40 acres, but to establish a long-term model in which agriculture, conservation, housing, and community benefit reinforce one another. **Talking Horse Ranch is currently the only property on San Juan Island that offers these overlapping benefits that cross-pollinate to meet essential needs of our time, positioning San Juan County to set yet another precedent – a model of farming that could provide stability in an unstable time, when given the chance.**

Attachments

- A. [Partial Assumption & Assignment Agreement to Talking Horse Ranch PSA](#)
- B. [Intro to The Farmland Commons](#)
- C. [Acquisition Budget](#)
- D. [Funding Approval Letter](#)
- E. [Operations Budget](#)
- F. [Code Analysis](#)
- G. [Site Map](#)
- H. [Valuation Considerations](#)
- I. [Market Garden](#)
- J. [The Farmers Land Trust Letter](#)
- K. [Signed Letter of Recommendation_ Greg Ingram_ current owner](#)
- L. [Letters of Support](#)

Additional Material Provided to Land Bank Director through Legal Counsel

- M. **Agriculture Conservation Easement**
- N. **Trail Easement**